

Boston’s Center Patchwork: Center-by-Committee Without Redundant Skillsets (Queta / Garza / Vučević)

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1 Executive Summary

This season, Boston has had to operate without its previous championship center infrastructure of Horford, Kornet, and Porziņģis, and without Tatum, who has yet to return after rupturing his Achilles. The response has been a center-by-committee approach where each big fills a distinct role. Neemias Queta anchors the interior with rim pressure, rebounding, and defense, Luka Garza provides spacing and offensive versatility, and trade-deadline acquisition Nikola Vučević adds a skilled, high-touch connector who stabilizes non-Queta minutes without changing Joe Mazzulla’s foundation.

2 Timeline + Context

2.1 Pre-Deadline: Survival Minutes Without Redundancy

Heading into the season, Boston’s center minutes were a question mark, with responsibilities shifting based on matchup and lineup context. Queta handled the non-negotiables, anchoring the paint, rim-running, and securing the defensive glass, giving the Celtics interior stability they could not replicate elsewhere. Garza filled the complementary gaps, particularly with bench units, where his spacing and offensive skill fit seamlessly within Boston’s system. While both played well, Joe Mazzulla’s structure turned the position from a question mark into a functional, reliable part of the rotation.

2.2 Deadline: Adding a “Skills” Big Without Changing Identity

Boston’s bet on Vučević was not to replace Queta, but to stabilize the non-Queta minutes. He fits similarly to Garza as a spacing-capable connector with strong feel, but with greater size, touch, and overall offensive versatility, giving Boston a more ideal version of that role. Just as important, Boston did not change its identity with the move.

3 Rotation Snapshot + Comparative Roles

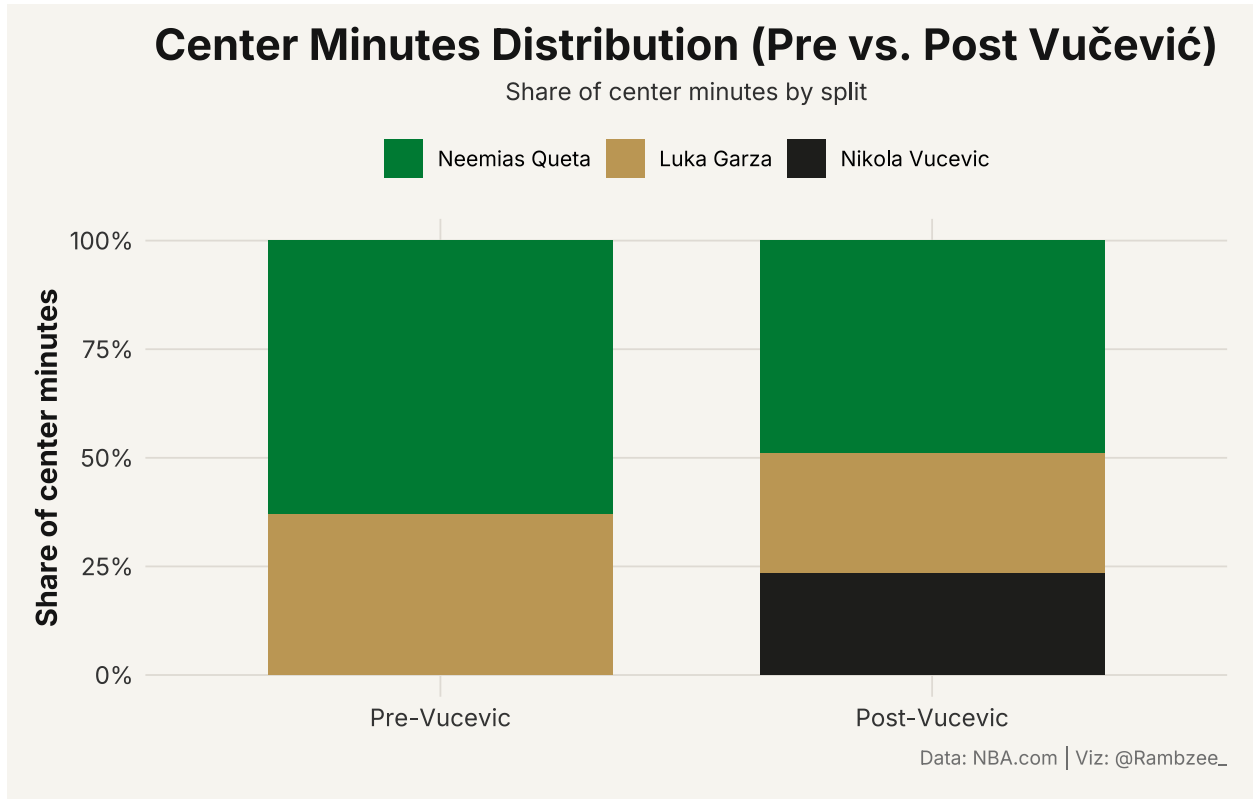
Table 1: Celtics center production snapshot (through All-Star break)

PLAYER NAME	AGE	GP	GS	MPG	FG	FGA	FG PCT	FG3	FG3A	FG3 PCT	ORB	DRB	TRB	AST	BLK	TOV	PTS
Nikola Vucevic	35	3	0	26.0	5.3	11.0	0.485	1.7	4.0	0.417	3.3	6.3	9.7	2.3	1.0	2.7	13.7
Neemias Queta	26	51	50	25.1	4.1	6.5	0.639	0.0	0.1	0.000	3.0	5.3	8.3	1.5	1.3	1.1	9.7
Luka Garza	27	45	4	16.7	2.8	4.8	0.583	0.7	1.6	0.438	2.4	1.8	4.2	1.0	0.5	0.6	7.8

Table 2: Center minutes share (split at 2026-02-06)

split	player	gp	minutes	min share
Post-Vucevic	Neemias Queta	28	707	48.9%
Post-Vucevic	Luka Garza	27	400	27.7%
Post-Vucevic	Nikola Vucevic	16	338	23.4%
Pre-Vucevic	Neemias Queta	48	1220	63.1%
Pre-Vucevic	Luka Garza	42	713	36.9%

3.1 Center-by-Committee Minutes Share (Pre vs. Post Vučević)



4 On/Off Impact (Directional Anchor)

Table 3: Center on/off deltas (directional; Vučević low sample)

player	min on	min off	off delta	def delta	net delta
Neemias Queta	1280	1322	-1.2	-8.5	7.2
Nikola Vučević	78	2524	-9.3	-6.9	-2.4
Luka Garza	749	1853	1.0	4.1	-3.1

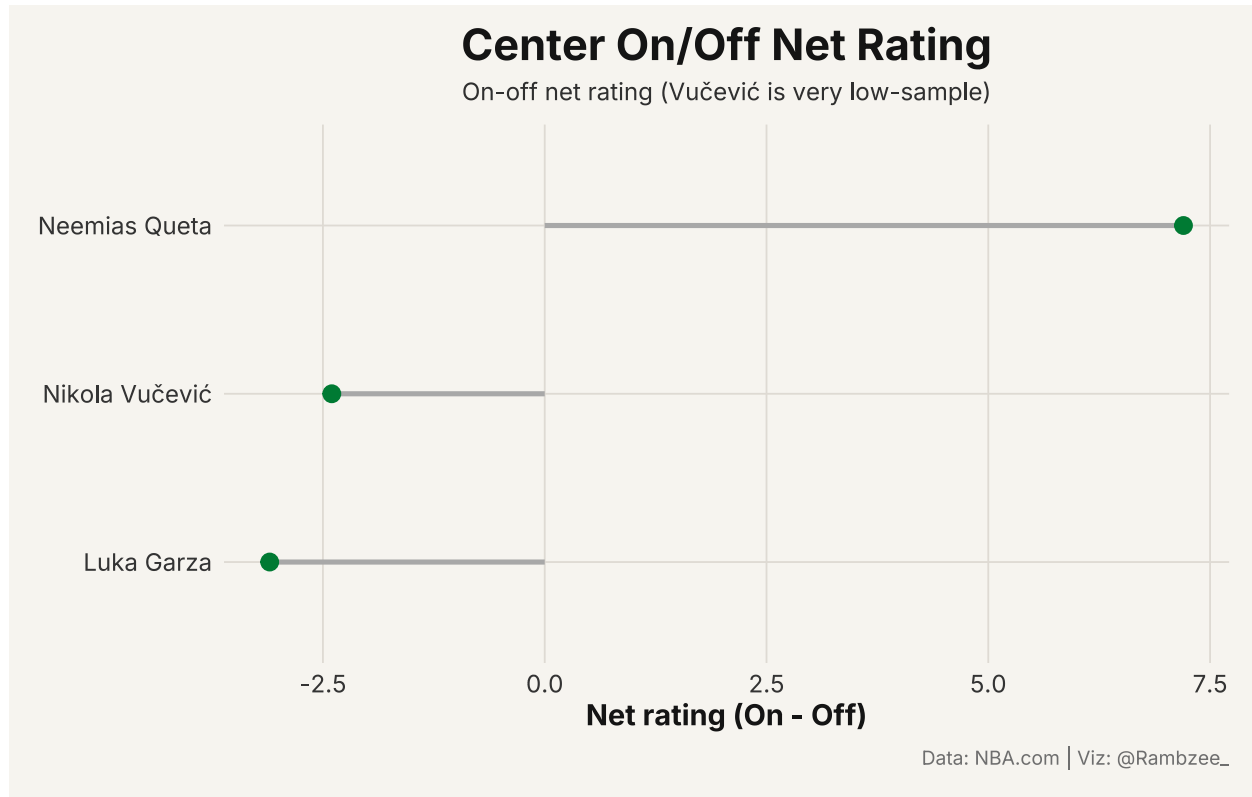


Table 4: On/off mechanism deltas

player	off ts delta	off tov delta	off orb delta	def ts delta	def tov delta	def orb delta
Luka Garza	-1.2	0.1	4.8	2.2	-1.6	-2.4
Neemias Queta	-0.7	-0.4	-0.1	-4.1	1.1	0.3
Nikola Vučević	-4.1	0.7	-0.3	-2.9	3.9	0.0

Queta has provided the clearest impact, anchoring Boston's defense and driving a +7.2 net rating swing behind rim protection, defensive rebounding, and interior presence. Even without driving offense, his ability to clean up possessions and protect the paint gives Boston a defensive floor it otherwise lacks.

Garza's value shows up more on the offensive side, where Boston maintains efficiency and generates extra possessions through offensive rebounding, helping bench units sustain flow. Vučević's sample is extremely small, but his role projects similarly as a connector who keeps the offense organized through spacing, touch, and decision-making, giving Boston a more scalable offensive option in non-Queta minutes.

5 Comparative Strengths (Role Marker Separation)

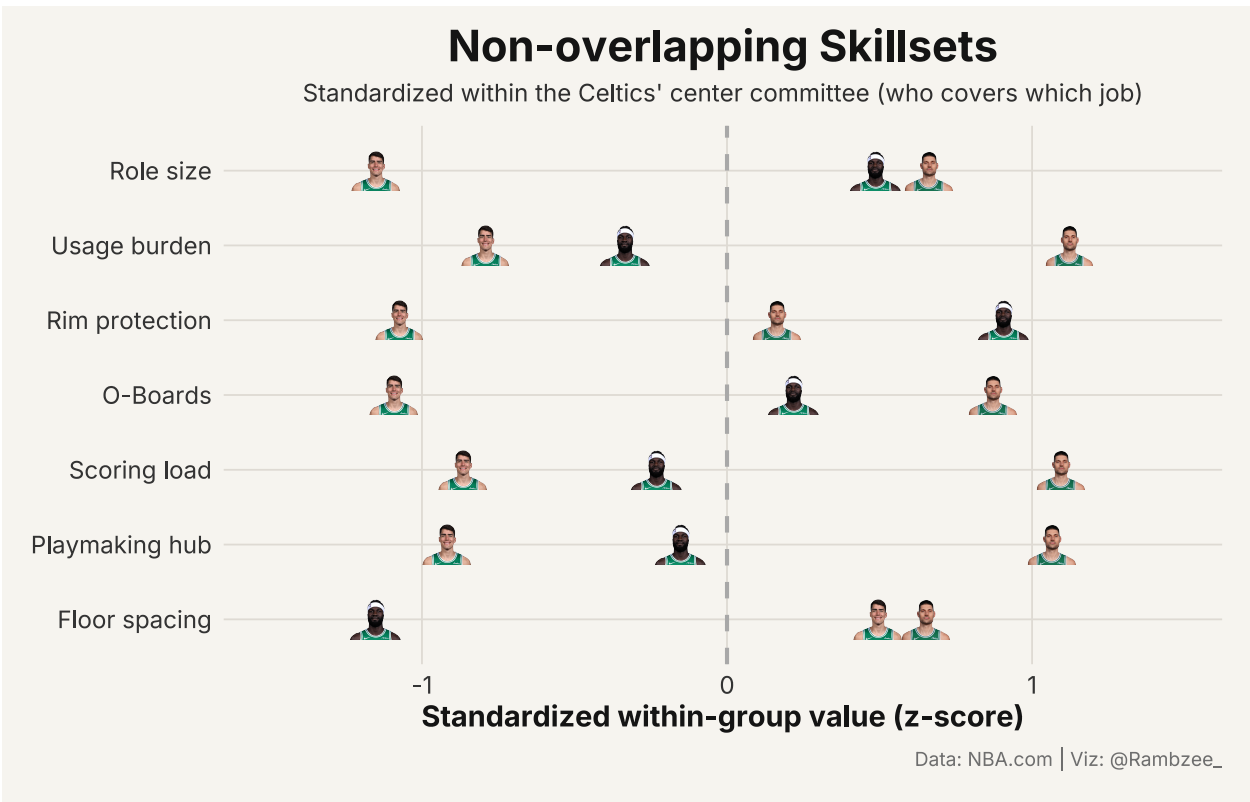


Figure 1: Center role markers (standardized within this 3-player group).

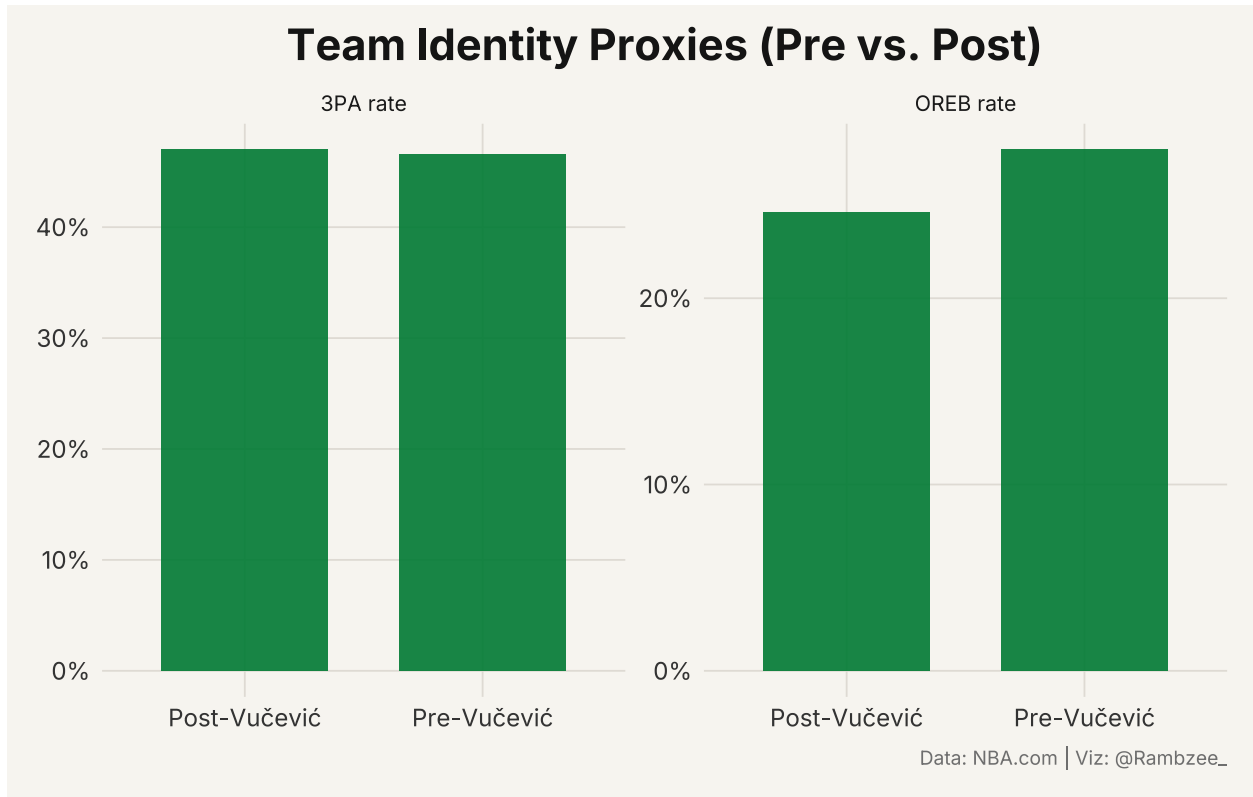
Each center covers a different job. Queta carries the defensive and interior workload, Garza keeps lineups functional with spacing and offensive feel, and Vučević adds a higher-usage offensive hub with real scoring punch. The result is full role coverage across the position without forcing Boston to compromise how it plays.

6 System Preservation Checks (Team Identity)

6.1 Shot Profile + Rebounding Stability (Pre vs. Post)

Table 5: Team identity proxies (3PA rate, OREB rate) from team gamelog

split	games	threepa rate	oreb rate
Post-Vučević	31	0.470	0.246
Pre-Vučević	51	0.466	0.280



In his limited time with the team, Vučević has not meaningfully changed how Boston plays. He has spent more time operating around the paint and rim, which may explain the slight dip in three-point attempts and increase in offensive rebounds, but the sample is still too small to draw firm conclusions.

7 How Vučević Can Help

Table 6: Team offensive rebounding leaders

Rank	Team	ORB
1	Houston	15.8
2	Portland	14.3
3	New York	13.2
4	Detroit	13.1
5	Phoenix	12.9
6	Boston	12.8
7	Charlotte	12.4

Vučević brings a strong rebounding presence, with elite size, strength, and veteran positioning on the glass. Boston has already stabilized in that area after a slow start, and his addition only reinforces that advantage.

Despite consistently creating open shots, Boston ranks in the bottom three in assists per game, reflecting its spacing-driven offense. Vučević adds needed playmaking, averaging 4.5 assists per 100 possessions compared to roughly 3 per 100 from Garza at 3.1 and Queta at 3. He is comfortable facilitating from the short roll and acting as a connector, helping keep possessions organized without disrupting Boston's spacing.

Table 7: Team defensive rebounding rankings

Rank	Team	DRB
10	Denver	33.1
11	Houston	32.8
12	Boston	32.6
13	Detroit	32.5
14	Utah	32.5
15	Milwaukee	32.5

Table 8: Team assist rankings

Rank	Team	AST
28	Houston	24.7
29	Boston	23.9
30	Clippers	23.5

8 What Changes When Tatum Returns

Tatum’s potential return restores the reliable elite advantage creation Boston has been missing. He is an elite defensive rebounder and one of the most switchable defenders in the league, capable of matching up with wings, forwards, and even centers when needed. While Boston has remained solid on the glass, Tatum raises that ceiling further and helps insulate some of the defensive limitations of more offense-oriented centers like Vučević and Garza.

Offensively, Tatum also gives Boston a primary creator that elevates the effectiveness of its centers. His ability to handle the ball, draw help, and create advantages allows Queta to thrive as a rim roller and finisher, while giving Vučević more opportunities to operate as a pick-and-pop threat and short-roll connector. Rather than needing to create offense themselves, the centers can play off Tatum’s gravity, reinforcing their complementary roles within Boston’s system.

9 Conclusion

- Boston addressed the center position through complementary roles rather than a single replacement.
- Queta anchored the defense and rebounding, Garza preserved spacing and offensive flow, and Vučević adds a higher-skill offensive connector.
- Team identity remained intact, with Boston maintaining its spacing, rebounding, and efficiency profile with any of their centers.
- Tatum’s potential return further strengthens the team by improving rebounding, defensive versatility, and offensive creation.